The energy, the enthusiasm, the intensity were fantastic.

'Catch it! Catch it!'

Our anguished cries echoed from the yard through the house, famously waking my father, who worked hard as a GP in town and was accustomed to returning home for an early afternoon nap.

'Catch it! Catch it!'

'Keep quiet!' he would bellow from my parents' bedroom.

And we would keep quiet, at least until the next half-chance.

'Catch it! Catch it!'

Our lives revolved around sport, any sport, any time, any place.

Cricket? There was the A field at Div Park and the B field in the back yard, but there was also the driveway where the ball skidded nicely off the paving stones and there was occasionally the street outside our home, and we also spent hour after hour practising our slip catches in the swimming pool, hurling the ball at each other and diving around.

Golf? In decent weather, we played holes created around the garden, around that tree, over that bush. If it was raining, we played inside the house, using only a wedge and a putter on an improvised course that included a tricky Par 3 under the table in the living room and a demanding Par 5 running down the passage from our parents' bedroom, past our bedrooms, past the dining room and into the bar area; birdies were very rare on that hole, largely because you had to putt on the rugs and we used to place cushions underneath the rugs to change the contours of our 'greens'.

For swimming, there was of course the pool, but mere lengths from one end to the other were never going to fulfil our foolish quest for excitement and adrenalin, so we created a game that, looking back, was unbelievably dangerous but which at the time seemed just about the best imaginable source of fun.

We would climb onto the roof of the house and jump down from there into the pool below but, to land safely in the water, we had to jump out at